

Foreign government certificates provide assurance that food safety hazards associated with the production and processing of food are managed under the oversight of Competent Authorities.

[Competent Authorities](#) in exporting countries issue these certificates with statements agreed by Australia.

At the border, all consignments are checked to verify the validity of the government certificate. The rate of inspection of these consignments is reduced to 5%, after the initial import passes inspection and analysis.

All biosecurity import conditions must be met before food safety requirements apply.

Check our [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#) for biosecurity import conditions and [food safety requirements](#).

Some food must be imported with a recognised foreign government certificate. The certificate is negotiated under a mandatory government certification arrangement.

Countries wanting to export these foods into Australia must first [apply](#) to have a certification arrangement. Applications must be from the relevant competent authority in the exporting country.

Mandatory foreign government certification is needed to import:

Some food classified as risk food can be imported with a recognised foreign government certificate. The certificate is negotiated under a voluntary government certification arrangement.

A competent authority in the exporting country can apply for a voluntary government certification arrangement with Australia.

Food covered by a recognised foreign government certificate in a voluntary arrangement, assures us that food safety hazards are being managed and consequently, is tested at a lower rate. This can reduce border clearance processes. If non-compliance is detected, inspection/ testing is increased.

## **Certification arrangements**

Voluntary arrangements exist with Canada and Thailand for the seafood listed:

- [processed bivalve molluscs and bivalve mollusc products](#) (Thailand only)
- [cooked crustaceans](#)
- [histamine susceptible fish](#)
- [processed finfish ready to eat](#).

If these products have a recognised government foreign certificate, it may reduce inspection and testing.

Only a government [Competent Authority](#) can apply for a government certification arrangement.

Importers and overseas companies wanting to import/export food that requires a government certification arrangement should contact the relevant authority in the exporting country.

Competent Authorities can request more information by emailing the Director, Imported Food section at: [ifis-certification@aff.gov.au](mailto:ifis-certification@aff.gov.au).

## **Assessment**

We assess the exporting country's system for the production and processing of food covered by the application. It must provide equivalent food safety outcomes to Australia's system. Our process aligns with Codex Alimentarius guidelines for assessing equivalence and negotiating certification.

Biosecurity import conditions are not within scope of our assessment of food safety equivalence.

Our process includes these steps:

- Initial discussions and application
- Equivalence assessment process
- Negotiation of arrangement and certificate.

## **Eligibility**

A country must provide information on:

- all relevant national Competent Authorities and their responsibilities
- food safety laws and administrative systems governing safety of the food
- government food safety controls and export conditions managing foodborne hazards associated with the food
- verification and enforcement of compliance with national standards, government controls and export conditions
- laboratory testing competency.

## **Competent Authority**

The government authority or official body authorised by the government that is responsible for the setting of regulatory food safety requirements and/or for the organisation of official controls including enforcement.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/goods/food/mandatory-government-certification>